

Frontend Forms & User Input

Sending data from the browser to the server

What We'll Cover

- How HTML forms submit data
- `express.urlencoded()` middleware
- Reading form data with `req.body`
- The Post/Redirect/Get pattern
- Shared create/edit templates
- Route ordering pitfalls
- Delete via POST



Code examples use a **blog posts** domain – you'll apply these patterns to your **expenses** app in the exercise

How HTML Forms Work

A form collects user input and sends it to the server

```
<form method="POST" action="/posts">
  <input type="text" name="title" />
  <input type="text" name="body" />
  <button type="submit">Add post</button>
</form>
```

Three key attributes:

Attribute	Purpose	Example
method	HTTP verb to use	POST
action	URL to send data to	/posts
name	Key for each field's value	title

What Happens When a Form Submits?

The browser sends a POST request with URL-encoded data

```
POST /posts HTTP/1.1
Content-Type: application/x-www-form-urlencoded

title=Hello+World&body=My+first+post
```

- Each `<input name=" ... ">` becomes a **key=value** pair
- Pairs are joined with `&`
- Special characters are percent-encoded

This is the same format as query strings, but sent in the **request body**.

Parsing Form Data in Express

Express doesn't parse form bodies by default

```
// index.ts – add BEFORE your routes
app.use(express.urlencoded({ extended: true }));
```

Without this middleware: `req.body` is `undefined`

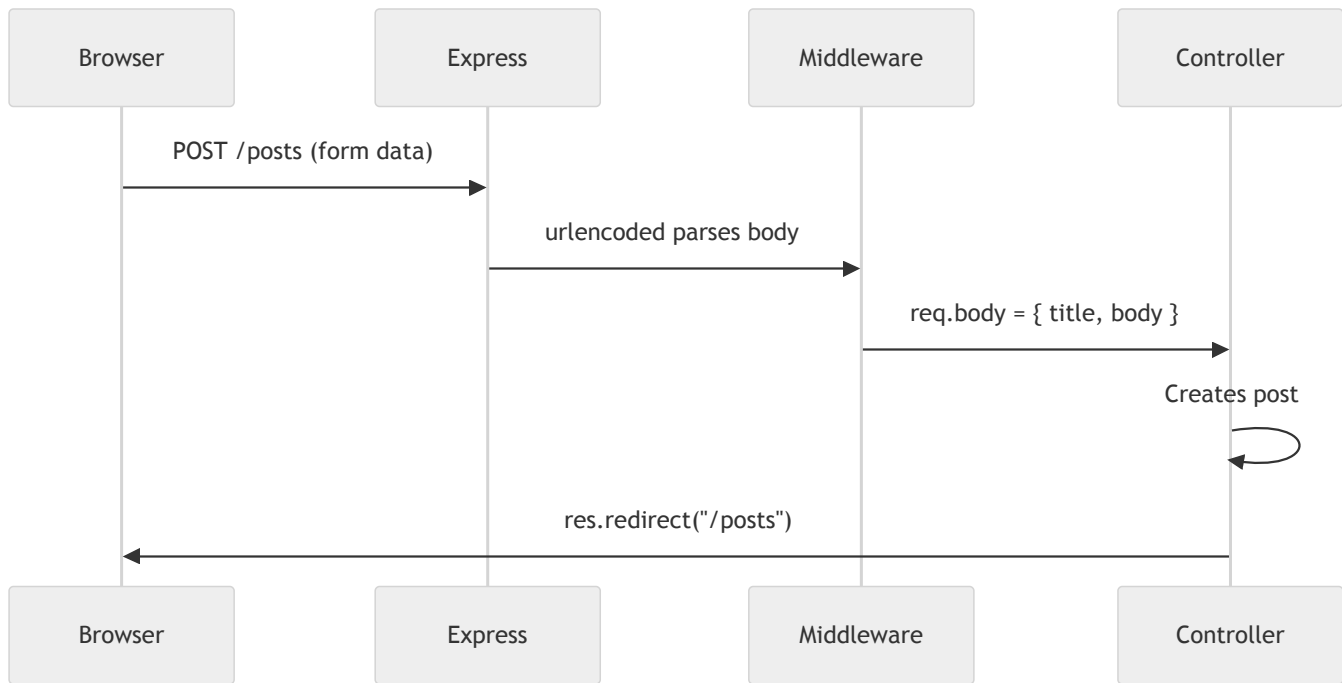
With this middleware: `req.body` is an object

```
// After the form from slide 3 submits:
req.body = {
  title: "Hello World",
  body: "My first post" // ⚠ Always a string!
}
```

All form values arrive as **strings** – parse numbers with `Number()` or `parseFloat()` where needed.

The Data Flow

From `<input>` to controller

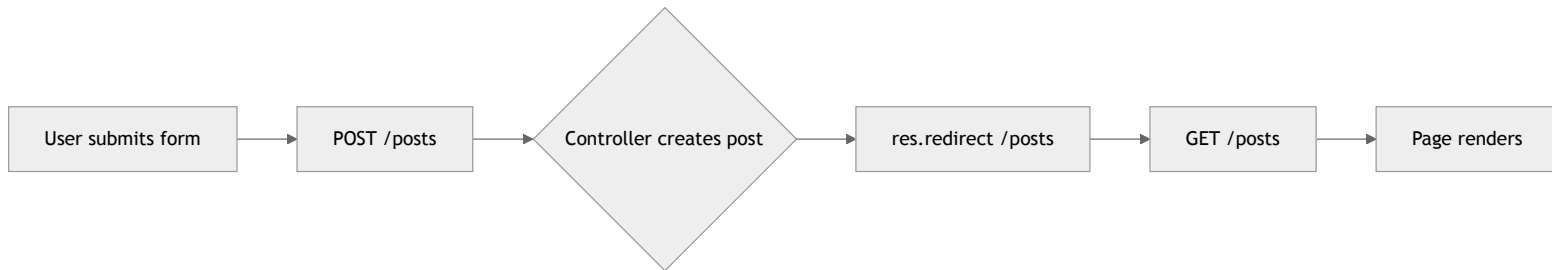


The `name` attribute on each `<input>` determines the key in `req.body`.

Post/Redirect/Get (PRG)

Why controllers redirect after form submissions

The problem: If the server renders a page directly after a POST, refreshing the page re-submits the form – creating duplicates.



The rule: After any create, update, or delete → **redirect, don't render.**

```
// ✅ Correct – PRG pattern
```

```
res.redirect("/posts");
```

```
// ❌ Wrong – refreshing re-submits the form
```

```
res.render("pages/posts.njk", { posts });
```

PRG: What the User Sees

The redirect is invisible to the user

Step	HTTP	What happens
1	POST /posts	Form data sent to server
2	302 Found → /posts	Server responds with redirect
3	GET /posts	Browser follows redirect automatically
4	200 OK	Page renders – safe to refresh

Open DevTools → Network tab to see the 302 redirect in action.

Route Ordering Matters

Static routes must come before dynamic parameters

```
// ✅ Correct order
router.get("/posts/new", controller.showCreateForm); // static
router.get("/posts/:id", controller.getById);        // dynamic

// ❌ Wrong order – "new" is treated as an :id
router.get("/posts/:id", controller.getById);        // catches "new"!
router.get("/posts/new", controller.showCreateForm); // never reached
```

Why? Express matches routes top-to-bottom. `:id` matches **any** string – including `"new"`.

Rule of thumb: Specific routes first, parameterised routes after.

Full Route Table

Method	Path	Purpose
GET	/posts	List all
GET	/posts/new	Show create form
GET	/posts/:id	View one
GET	/posts/:id/edit	Show edit form
POST	/posts	Create (from form)
POST	/posts/:id/edit	Update (from form)
POST	/posts/:id/delete	Delete

Notice: forms only use **GET** and **POST** – no PUT or DELETE.

Why No PUT or DELETE?

HTML forms only support GET and POST

❌ This does NOT work in browsers →

```
<form method="DELETE" action="/posts/1">
```

✅ Instead, use POST with a descriptive path →

```
<form method="POST" action="/posts/1/delete">
```

- The `<form>` element only allows `method="GET"` or `method="POST"`
- APIs use PUT/DELETE, but **server-rendered forms** cannot
- Convention: use the URL path to indicate the action (`/edit` , `/delete`)

Some frameworks add a hidden `_method` field to work around this. We'll keep it simple with POST.

GOV.UK Form Components

Building accessible forms with the Design System

```
<div class="govuk-form-group">  
  <label class="govuk-label" for="title">Title</label>  
  <input class="govuk-input" id="title"  
    name="title" type="text" />  
</div>
```

GOV.UK Form Components

Key classes:

Class	Purpose
<code>govuk-form-group</code>	Wraps label + input with spacing
<code>govuk-label</code>	Styled label
<code>govuk-input</code>	Styled text input
<code>govuk-button</code>	Primary action button
<code>govuk-button--warning</code>	Red destructive button



GOV.UK Text Input

Shared Create/Edit Template

One template handles both creating and editing

```
<h1 class="govuk-heading-l">
  {% if post %}Edit Post{% else %}New Post{% endif %}
</h1>

<form method="POST"
  action="{% if post %}/posts/{{ post.id }}/edit
    {% else %}/posts{% endif %}">

  <div class="govuk-form-group">
    <label class="govuk-label" for="title">Title</label>
    <input class="govuk-input" id="title" name="title"
      value="{{ post.title if post else '' }}" />
  </div>

  <button class="govuk-button">
    {% if post %}Update{% else %}Add{% endif %} post
  </button>
</form>
```

How the Shared Template Works

The controller decides what data to pass

```
// Show empty form → no post passed
showcreateForm(req: Request, res: Response) {
  res.render("pages/post-form.njk");
}

// Show pre-filled form → post object passed
showeditform(req: Request, res: Response) {
  const post = this.service.getById(req.params.id);
  res.render("pages/post-form.njk", { post });
}
```

Scenario	post variable	Form action	Button text
Create	undefined	/posts	"Add post"
Edit	{ id, title, ... }	/posts/1/edit	"Update post"

Delete via POST

A form disguised as a button

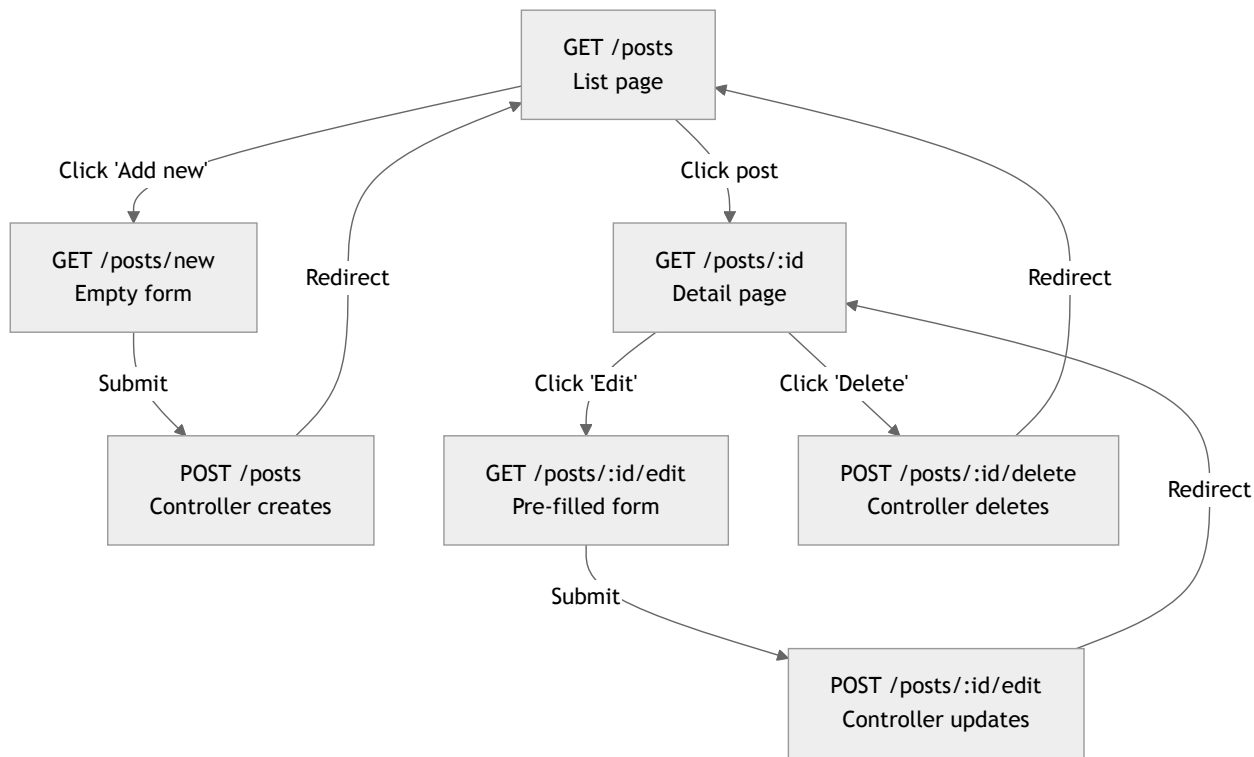
```
<!-- On the detail page -->
<form method="POST" action="/posts/{{ post.id }}/delete"
      style="display: inline;">
  <button type="submit"
        class="govuk-button govuk-button--warning"
        data-module="govuk-button">
    Delete this post
  </button>
</form>
```

- Uses `govuk-button--warning` for a red destructive style
- `display: inline` keeps it on the same line as other links
- The controller deletes the expense and **redirects** (PRG pattern)

Stretch goal: Add a confirmation page before actually deleting.

The Complete Flow

Create, Read, Update, Delete



Key Takeaways

- Forms use `method` , `action` , and `name` to send data to the server
- `express.urlencoded()` parses form data into `req.body`
- **Post/Redirect/Get** prevents duplicate submissions on refresh
- Route ordering matters – static routes before `:id` parameters
- HTML forms only support **GET** and **POST** – use URL paths for edit/delete
- A single Nunjucks template can handle both create and edit with conditionals

Exercise Time

Add forms to your expenses frontend – create, edit, and delete!